ER OON Operating Model 2027: Executive Summary

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Summary

We will replace 12 facility teams with **10 full-cycle teams**, one per manager, and add a **5-person US Gateway Desk** that files disputes Lebanon prepares in our IDR Prep Studio (**Model C, proposed**). It goes live before the IDR Gateway becomes US-only on **January 1, 2027**. No one loses their job or pay because of the restructure; from December 2027 everyone is held to the same badge and performance standards.

Why now. Three pressures arrive together:

- **The IDR Gateway goes US-only on January 1.** Our negotiators spend 50–70% of their time in it today.
- **Workload is uneven.** It varies 5× between facility teams (138 to 704 open claims per person).
- **We're growing.** We go from 12 to 31 facilities in two years.

What changes:

1. **One owner per account.** Each RCM Specialist owns an account from coding to final payment. This replaces the coder, biller and negotiator handoffs.
2. **Teams own payer portfolios, not facilities.** Workload is balanced by effort, and new facilities join existing teams instead of creating new ones.
3. **A guided copy desk for the Gateway.** Lebanon prepares every dispute in the IDR Prep Studio, which mirrors the Gateway page by page and checks every field. The US desk copies it into the Gateway in about 15 minutes and submits it. Pricing and strategy stay in Lebanon.
4. **Pay and promotion follow skill.** Six levels (L0–L5) are earned through 15 skill badges in three families: C Core, B Specialist and A Advanced. L1 and L2 come automatically once the badges are held; L3, L4 and L5 need a leveling test, and L5 is the leadership level for team leads and managers. Every December the top 10% of each level earn their missing badges. Badges are earned in quarterly test windows and kept through a semiannual review.

5. **A fair transition.** The top 10% of each role earn their role badges without tests. Everyone else has 3 months of tests, and the bottom 10% restart at L1 through the Academy. No one's pay goes down, and every move up comes with a raise.

Decisions requested:

- [ ] Approve Model C: a 5-person US Gateway Desk (1 lead, 4 associates) plus 2 staff on 3–6 month contracts until March 15, 2027, hired in-house from October.
- [ ] Approve moving to 10 full-cycle teams in January–February 2027.
- [ ] Approve the six levels (L0–L5), 15 badges, leveling tests, the quarterly test windows and the semiannual review, including the badge-loss rules, subject to HR and legal review.
- [ ] Approve the January–March 2027 transition plan, with pay protection and guaranteed raises on upgrade.
- [ ] Approve the opt-in bridge night rota and its $30,000 quarterly bonus pool.
- [ ] Approve the Senior Manager role and the 11 manager portfolios.
- [ ] Approve closing NNSA claims older than 12 months, after a final high-dollar review.

Operating model

The 94 people in Lebanon are organized as 10 identical teams, with 2 floating team leads who cover absences and support the Academy. A 5-person US desk enters our prepared work into the Gateway. QA stays the separate department it is today.

Unit	People	Reports to	Owns
Full-cycle teams (10)	Each: 1 manager, 1 team lead, 7–8 RCM specialists; plus 2 floating team leads	Head of ER OON Revenue Cycle	A balanced book of payers, from coding to final payment
Bridge night rota	Opt-in L2–L4 members, 2 a night, 16:00–24:00 Beirut	Onshore–Offshore Liaison owner	Ticket checks, answers to the US desk within 15 minutes, same-day fixes

Unit	People	Reports to	Owns
US Gateway Desk (Model C)	1 lead, 4 associates; 2 more on contract until March 15, 2027	Head of ER OON Revenue Cycle	Copying prepared disputes from the IDR Prep Studio into the Gateway; no pricing decisions
QA department (existing)	No change	No change	QA checklists, audit sample, seat on the Badge Panel

Manager portfolios. Each manager, and the new Senior Manager, owns one of 11 portfolios on top of their team, and reports on it monthly to the leadership board. Three examples:

- **Training Academy:** test windows, badge records, the semiannual review and the transition.
- **Pricing guide:** offer pricing and payer playbooks.
- **Onshore–Offshore Liaison:** the US desk, the bridge night rota and the accounting teams.

How work is assigned: by payer portfolio in three tiers, weighted by effort:

- **Tier 1** goes to L3 and L4 Senior Specialists: highest-dollar claims and the hardest payers.
- **Tier 2** is standard NSA work.
- **Tier 3** is lower-dollar, high-volume claims.

Careers:

Level	Requirement
L0 Junior RCM Specialist	New hire; no badges yet
L1 RCM Specialist I	All 5 C badges; automatic
L2 RCM Specialist II	5 C + B1 or B2 + 2 of B3, B4, B5; automatic
L3 Senior Specialist I	5 C + 5 B + 1 of 5 A; L3 leveling test
L4 Senior Specialist II	5 C + 5 B + 3 of 5 A; L4 leveling test

Level	Requirement
L5 Principal: Team Lead	5 C + 5 B + 4 of 5 A; L5 leveling test with coaching assessment; team lead post
L5 Principal: Manager	5 C + 5 B + 4 of 5 A; L5 leveling test with leadership assessment; manager post

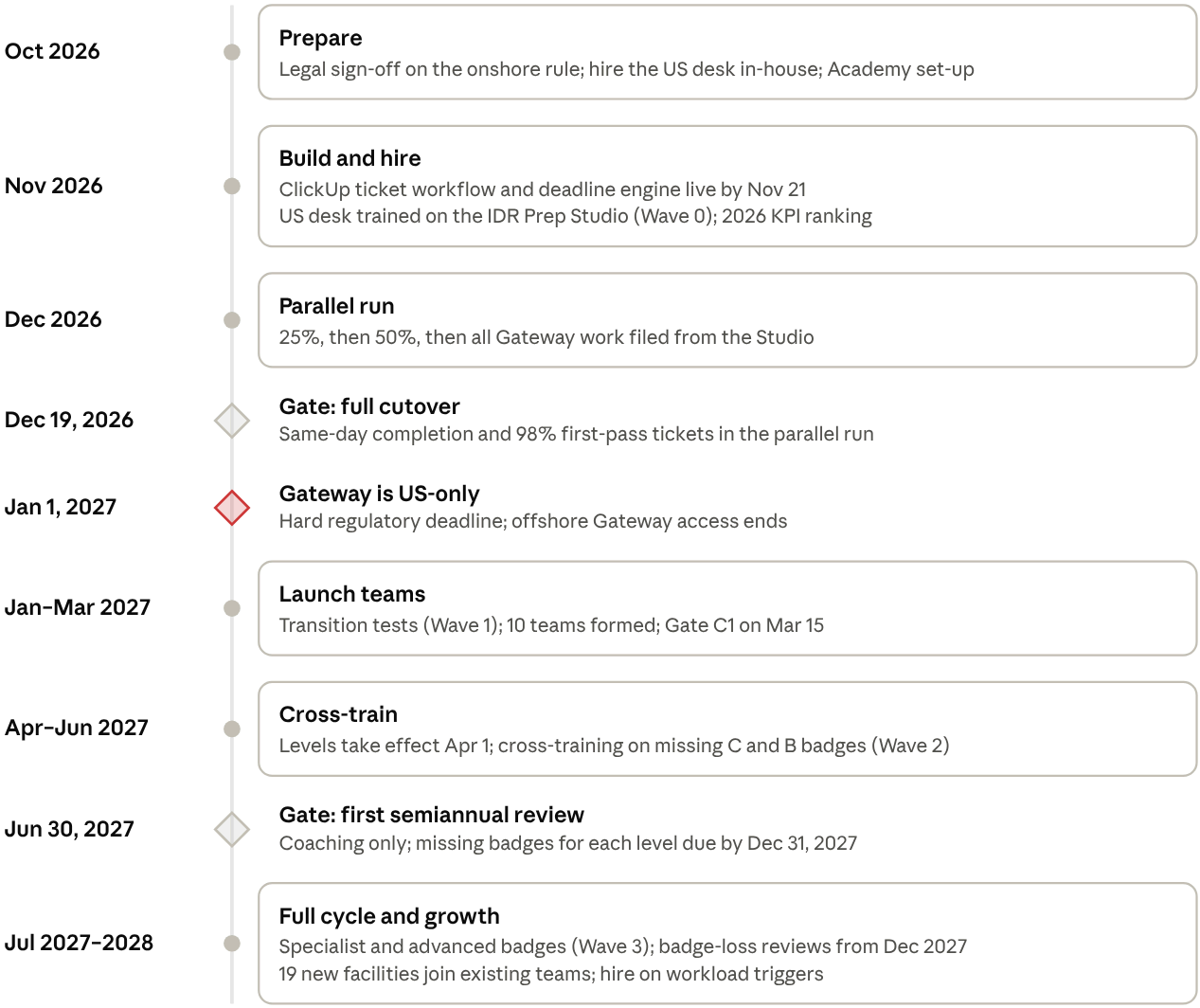
Members who lose 25% of their badges at a semiannual review go on probation and coaching; losing 50% leads to termination, from December 2027. The full rules are in the Badges, Levels and Transition appendix and the badge competency matrix.

Implementation roadmap

The Gateway work is done and stable before team structure changes. The cutover is on December 19, which leaves two weeks of margin before the January 1 deadline.

The Gateway goes live before the team structure changes

Phases in order, October 2026 to 2028. Diamonds are gates; the red one is the hard regulatory deadline.



implementation roadmap · 6 phases, 3 gates

New facilities open straight into the 10 teams; a new team is added only when existing teams run above 110% of target workload for 4 weeks.

Training plan and strategy

Training is built around badges and done on live work, with a badge-holder checking. The Academy Committee runs it, L4 Senior Specialists II and team leads teach, and the QA department scores quality.

Wave	When	Who	What	Done when
0 · US desk	Nov–Dec 2026	US desk (5, plus 2 on contract)	HIPAA, the IDR Prep Studio copy desk, each Gateway action, escalation path; then the December parallel run	15 minutes or less per dispute and under 0.5% errors in the parallel run
0 · Studio and tickets	Nov 2026	Negotiators and bridge night rota volunteers	Preparing disputes in the IDR Prep Studio; night rota duties	98% first-pass accuracy in the parallel run
Ranking	Dec 2026	Everyone	Ranking within each current role on 2026 KPIs; top and bottom 10% published	Lists checked and published
1 · Transition	Jan–Mar 2027	Everyone	Top 10% receive their role badges (Negotiator: C2, C5, B2, B5, A2; Coder: C1, C5, B1, A3; Biller: C1–C4, B5, plus B3 for MVA or workers' comp); bottom 10% join the Academy at L1; everyone else takes the optional skill assessment and role badge tests in the February or March window	Levels take effect on April 1, 2027

Wave	When	Who	What	Done when
2 · Missing badges	Apr–Dec 2027	Anyone missing a badge for their level	Cross-training on the missing badges: negotiators learn C1, C3 and C4; coders learn C2, C3 and C4; billers learn C5; each paired with a badge-holder in their team	All badges for the confirmed level by December 31, 2027
3 · Specialist and advanced	Jul 2027 on	L1 and above	B badges (coding, IDR process, MVA and workers' comp, payer strategy, payer outreach) and A badges (reporting, IDR strategy, medical terminology, billing strategy, innovation)	At least 2 holders of every badge in every team
New hires	Monthly from 2027	Groups of 4–6 at L0	2 weeks of Academy, then the C badges with supervised work in a team	L1 automatically at about 6 months

Guidelines:

- **Protect the time.** Everyone in Wave 2 gets 4 hours a week, about 7 FTE in total. Today's spare capacity covers it.
- **Never assess your own team.** Badge Panels (a QA reviewer plus 2 L4 Senior Specialists II or team leads from other teams) score every test window.
- **Track it monthly.** Measure badges earned against plan, QA scores by badge, and time to proficiency for new hires; review every member's badges each June and December.

Estimated cost: US Gateway Desk (Model C)

The proposed 5-person desk costs roughly **$252,000–307,000 a year** as direct hires, about $280,000 at the midpoint. These are approximate market figures for Texas data-entry roles, not offers; replace them with our own pay offers before approval. We recruit in-house and the desk uses systems and equipment we already have, so there are no recruiting fees or setup costs.

Line	Basis	Annual cost (USD)
4 Gateway associates	Approximate Texas market rates for direct hires, plus about 25% benefits and payroll taxes	187,000–229,000
1 desk lead	Approximate Texas market rates for direct hires, plus about 25% benefits and payroll taxes	65,000–78,000
Run rate		**252,000–307,000**
Paid onboarding before go-live (one-time)	November–December salaries for the 5 permanent staff	42,000–51,000
Cutover buffer (one-time)	2 associates on contract, November to March 15, 2027	35,000–43,000

Against the alternatives: Model A (7 people typing from tickets) costs $346,000–421,000 a year. Model B (3 people with a form-filling Cockpit) costs $192,000–244,000, but needs written Gateway approval and new software. Model C saves $94,000–114,000 a year against Model A today. The full analysis is in the Model A vs B vs C comparison.

As volume grows, the desk scales on the backlog trigger, at about $47,000–57,000 per associate a year:

- About 8 people by the end of year 1: **$393,000–478,000**, against $580,000–707,000 under Model A.
- About 11 people by the end of year 2: **$533,000–650,000**, against $861,000–1,050,000 under Model A.
- If the Gateway allows bulk file upload, growth stays nearer the low end.

Hiring route: our in-house recruiting team hires 5 permanent staff and 2 on 3–6 month contracts from October, so everyone is in place for November onboarding. The contracts end at Gate C1 on March 15, 2027, once the desk holds 15 minutes per dispute, errors under 0.5% and no missed deadlines for 4 weeks.

The only new cost in Lebanon is the bridge night rota:

- Bridge night rota: a $30,000 quarterly bonus pool, up to $120,000 a year, shared at $300–3,000 per member a quarter.

Technical needs

Most of the build is in ClickUp, which we already use. The hard deadline is the ticket workflow, which must be live by the December parallel run.

Need	What it does	By
IDR Prep Studio (Model C copy desk)	Internal portal that mirrors the Gateway page by page, validates every field, keeps documents in Drive and gives the US desk one-click copy and a confirmation PDF; already built	Ready now; used in the December parallel run
ClickUp ticket workflow	One form per Gateway action that is not filed from the Studio; status flows back from the US desk	Nov 21, 2026
Deadline engine	Business-day timers for every NSA step; alerts the team lead, then the manager, 3 days before a deadline	Nov 21, 2026
US desk access	Individual Gateway credentials with MFA; access to the Studio copy desk only, no eCW	Dec 1, 2026
Bridge night rota channel	Rota roster, a live chat channel and the nightly handover log in ClickUp	Dec 1, 2026

Need	What it does	By
HIPAA agreements	BAAs with ClickUp and our LLM provider	Before any PHI moves
Badge records and test windows	ClickUp fields for badges held, test enrolments and semiannual review results	Jan 2027
Work routing	Weighted work units, payer portfolio and badge fields, so ClickUp routes each task to a badge-holder and builds each person's Today list	Jan 2027
eCW	Role permissions and reports by team and payer portfolio instead of by facility	Jan 2027
Medical-necessity reports	Approved LLM tool under a BAA, with a versioned prompt library	Jan 2027
Dashboards	Net Recovery, deadlines, backlog and the team badge grid, from ClickUp and eCW exports	Feb 2027
Model web app	The Apps Script page that explains the model to staff	Ready now

Open question for the Gateway: does it accept bulk file upload for batched line items? The answer sets US desk size more than anything else.

Leadership approach

We lead this change by protecting people first, deciding close to the work, and changing one thing at a time.

Principles:

- **Gateway first, structure second.** The structure doesn't change until the Gateway cutover is stable, so any December problem has one cause.

- **No job or pay loss from the restructure.** Levels take effect on April 1, 2027, and badge-loss consequences start only with the December 2027 review.
- **Decisions close to the work.** Team leads approve settlements within set bands and rebalance their team; managers own results and people.
- **Open criteria.** Every badge, level, test and promotion rule is published before anyone is placed, and each person gets one appeal.
- **Measure before judging.** The June 2027 review is for coaching only. The only exception is missed deadlines, which get zero tolerance from day one.

Governance cadence:

Forum	When	Who	Decides
Team huddle	Daily, 10 minutes	Team lead and team	Deadlines due within 3 days, rebalancing
Managers' review	Weekly	10 managers, Head	Workload, US desk backlog, escalations
Leadership review	Monthly	Head, managers, QA	Net Recovery, badges against plan, hiring triggers
Promotions panel	Quarterly	Academy owner + 2 managers from other teams	Level changes and promotions

Communication sequence:

1. Leadership approval.
2. Manager briefing.
3. Team lead briefing, including choosing change champions.
4. All-hands meeting, covering "what changes for you", the transition plan and our commitments.
5. 1:1s within a week.
6. A published FAQ.

We repeat the cycle at each phase gate.

Top risks:

Risk	Response
We misread the Gateway rule	Legal sign-off before the build; offshore access stays as a fallback until Dec 19
The 5-person US desk falls behind	2 contract staff stay until Gate C1 on March 15; the backlog trigger adds staff within 2 weeks; the night rota reports it daily
Copy errors between the Studio and the Gateway	Field validation in the Studio, a per-field checklist and night rota review; errors under 0.5% at Gate C1
People see the new levels or tests as a threat	Top 10% earn badges without tests, protected pay, published criteria, one appeal, and consequences only from December 2027
We lose IDR experts	Early, open communication and a Senior Specialist path that doesn't require managing